



Subscribing via Syndirella

their own feeds set as default. As in any Web page display aggregator, to add more links, you will have to find news that interests you on the Internet. Copy the XML links and paste them in the Add RSS feed popup and click Download. The software then checks the validity of the link, and downloads the initial feed to display it. The advantage of this type of aggregator is that it looks and feels very similar to Outlook—a convenience for most users. Another advantage is that feeds can be kept for later referral. The individual feed settings include a customisable refresh time and also an automatic expiry or deletion of feeds after a user-specified time period.

Where to look

In order to receive updates and interesting articles, you have to first locate Web sites from where you can subscribe to news feeds. Syndic8 (www.syndic8.com) is one such site that hosts links to a variety of news and information, as well as links to popular blogs. Using Syndic8, you can search for topics, blogs and news agencies that offer you something of interest. Another such site is Meerkat at <http://www.oreillynet.com/meerkat/>, which allows you to scan through the news updates and blogs that were posted within the last hour. You can also conduct a regular search to find interesting information. NewsIsFree.com (www.newsisfree.com) allows you to build your own Web pages, within which you can include your choice of updates and news-feeds. myRSS at www.myRSS.com, also allows the creation of personal channels, where a user can select the type of feeds that appear on his or her channel. A highly comprehensive site called Moreover.com (http://w.moreover.com/main_site/solutions/pub_feeds.html) offers headlines from over 2,500 publications across the globe.

Jargon Buster

Mark-up language: A mark-up language is a coding system that is used to describe, structure and link documents. It is mainly used for structuring Web-based documents.

XML: XML, or eXtensible Mark-up Language, is a meta-language—language used to describe another language—that is used to create a standardised mark-up language. This is used to create highly structured documents for distribution over the Web. With XML, documents can have useful data and descriptions embedded in them, as all content is classified and tagged uniquely, thus allowing Web browsers or XML readers to easily recognise the document structure.

RSS: RSS, short for Rich Site Summary is an

application of XML, which reads and separates data from an XML document. RSS was originally developed for Netscape's My Netscape Network (MNN), and is used by aggregators to selectively choose content from Web pages, based on changes or updates. RSS is widely used by BBC, CNN, CNET, ZDNet, Slashdot, Motley Fool, Disney, Forbes and many more to share news and information.

Blog: A blog is a Web-based personal log, which is regularly updated with new information on the author's choice of subjects. The term Weblogging or blogging was coined in 1997 by Jorn Barger, who maintains a very popular blog at www.robotwisdom.com.

Where to use

With aggregator software, basic news is just the beginning. The true potential of user groups, Web forums or e-mail forums can be realised with aggregators. If you are part of a forum or user group, you will understand how frustrating it can be to keep visiting a site to check for updates on a message board, especially whilst waiting for a reply to a comment you made. With aggregators, as soon as a reply is posted, you are notified—you don't have refresh pages or check your inbox for alerts. All this obviously depends on whether the forum is based on XML or not, as the aggregator has to be able to understand the updates.

Also, while using aggregators, you don't need to wait for tiresome graphic-intensive Web pages to load. The aggregators run in the background and refresh automatically, thus saving time to leave you free to attend to other business. In a world where time is money, every second saved is a penny earned, and aggregators will do just that for you.

Being the Net junkies we are, we will never give up using the Web, and its billions of pages, to search for the proverbial needle-in-a-haystack. In no way will aggregation replace browsing or surfing the net, but it certainly makes for a more efficient way of keeping up with information from our favourite and most frequented sites. ■

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